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GLP-1 drugs drive losses at Blue Cross

High cost of weight loss treatments helps push insurer to second-worst year

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

Blue Cross Blue Shield of Massachusetts had one of its worst financial results in its history in 2025, underscoring the turbulence and disruption caused by ever-rising health care costs.

The state's largest health insurer on Friday reported it had an operating loss of \$380.5 million for 2025, second only to the year before. And once again, a large portion of that tide of red ink was attributed to the

popularity and high costs of GLP-1 weight loss drugs.

The situation underscores just how dominant those weight loss drugs have become in American society, not only in terms of their popularity, but also as a matter of urgent public policy, as the rapidly escalating outlays have blown holes in insurance coverage and triggered a backlash that's resulted in a pulling back of access.

For Blue Cross, losses are likely to continue into this year, despite the

insurer eliminating jobs, deploying computer algorithms to target doctors it believes are overcharging, restricting coverage of GLP-1 drugs for weight loss, and pushing back against health care providers seeking higher reimbursement rates.

The losses "are very material," said Mike Guerriere, chief actuary for Blue Cross Blue Shield of Massachusetts, in an interview. "We are looking at a three-year span where we may lose over \$1 billion."

There was no shortage of reasons for the financial pain this past year. A full one-third of the insurer's higher spending was driven by high pharmaceutical outlays, and much

of that was the cost and high volume of prescriptions for the blockbuster GLP-1 medications, which have long been used to treat diabetes but have become wildly popular to treat obesity.

Blue Cross Blue Shield took steps last year to curb those costs, announcing it would no longer automatically cover the drugs, known by brand names such as Wegovy or Zepbound, when prescribed solely for weight loss. But that decision didn't take effect until 2026, so the outlays on the drugs continued to weigh on the financials throughout 2025.

BLUE CROSS, Page A5

ICE finds detention centers a hard sell

Residents and officials — including Republicans — cite logistics and ethics

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — As the Trump administration moves to buy warehouses across the country to convert to massive immigrant detention centers, it is meeting a wall of resistance, even in Republican territory.

The most recent instance happened on Monday in Merrimack, N.H., where the intervention of Republican Governor Kelly Ayotte persuaded the administration to abandon the project after locals revolted over the plan to put the facility in their backyard. She isn't alone. Republican officials across the country have been nudging the administration to look elsewhere after their constituents have taken issue with the enforcement operations in their towns.

Immigration and Customs Enforcement is working to acquire warehouses nationwide as part of a plan to increase detention capacity by more than 90,000 beds, documents released by Ayotte show. The master plan is to have eight new large-scale detention centers and 16 smaller processing sites, like the one that had been planned in Merrimack. The \$38 billion effort was financed by the Republicans' party-line One Big Beautiful Bill and

ICE, Page A7

Student stays in Honduras after threat

US offers flight but won't promise not to detain her

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
and Camilo Fonseca

GLOBE STAFF

A wrongly deported Babson College student faces a new obstacle in her return to the United States when she declined Friday to fly home from Honduras after Trump administration officials threatened to again detain and expel her.

Any Lopez Belloza was slated to return to the US on Friday, months after the 20-year-old was detained while traveling to visit family for Thanksgiving and deported, and two weeks after a federal judge ordered she be returned to the country.

But federal prosecutors said in court filings Thursday that she would be subject to removal upon her return, despite ongoing legal proceedings over her immigration status.

Lopez Belloza, speaking to reporters virtually on Friday, said federal officials had told her on Thursday that she would be released from custody after returning to the US on a court-ordered flight.

But in filings in federal court, prosecutors seemed to contradict that offer, saying she was at risk of being swiftly deported again.

STUDENT, Page A7



PHOTOS BY SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Snow was loaded into a melter at the former Bayside Expo Center parking lot at Columbia Point in Dorchester.

IN THE MIDDLE OF A MELTDOWN

At city's snow farms, blizzard's bounty meets a quick, watery end



Snow from the piles was carried to the melter.

By Brian MacQuarrie

GLOBE STAFF

This is where mountains of snow from monster blizzards go to die: into a bubbling cauldron of steaming water atop an ungainly contraption of metal, pipes, and gauges that can eat as many as 135 tons of it an hour.

"It's a hot tub, basically," said Kevin O'Connor, flashing a satisfied smile Friday as he supervised a gurgling snow-melter near the former West Roxbury High School.

"It's fun for me, and we take a lot of pride in it," said O'Connor, 27, whose family business, LMA Services of Stoughton, had brought the melter to the city. "Actually, we're hoping for more snow."

Few people in Eastern Massachusetts and Rhode Island might share that sentiment, following two big, recent storms that have made this winter the snowiest in Boston in a decade. But more might be on the way early next week.

Thanks to the mechanical melters, thousands of truckloads of the white stuff have been transformed almost instantaneously into

SNOW, Page A5

For patients, a peaceful arrangement

Garden club brings color, calm to Emerson Hospital's psychiatric unit

By Kara Baskin

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

They usually arrive at Emerson Hospital in Concord through the emergency department. Some are immobilized by depression or anxiety; others are grappling with substance dependence or suicidal thoughts. And yet several floors up, on a 31-bed locked psychiatric unit, there is also hope, delivered in the form of flowers.

Most patients stay on Emerson's psychiatric floor for about eight days. Still, anyone who has languished in a hospital knows how medical time can feel elastic and looping: the same walls, the same faces, the same suspended reality.

But for two hours on a Friday morning, in a small art room, the mood shifts. A garden therapy program, run in partnership with the Acton Garden Club and Trader Joe's, brings a splash of color and a sense of agency to the unit — a groundedness amid isolation and loss of control.

Today, about a half-dozen patients are busy assembling bouquets: a musician, an artist, an active-

EMERSON, Page A10



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Jenni built a bouquet of flowers during the Acton Garden Club Flower Day at Emerson Hospital's psychiatric floor.



How thawed-ful

Saturday: Mostly sunny.
High: 45-50. Low: 28-33.

Sunday: Flurries.
High: 34-39. Low: 10-15.

High tide: 8:18 a.m. 9:04 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:21 Sunset: 5:33

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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The Pentagon has made a deal with Scouting America that Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said would refocus the organization away from "woke" policies he accused it of embracing in recent years. **A2.**

Pakistan and Afghanistan engaged in their fiercest clashes in years, escalating months of tension and border skirmishes into an open conflict. **A3.**

Two people from Massachusetts, a child and an adult, have been diagnosed with measles, the state's Department of Public Health said. **B1.**

Neil Sedaka died at 86. His musical career spanned many genres and seven decades. **C9.**

Klaviyo cofounders Ed Hallen and Andrew Bialecki are donating \$6 million toward an MIT effort aimed at keeping entrepreneurs in the area. **D1.**